



Caught IN THE WEB?

- Do not leave your personal documentation at places where it can be viewed by others.
- Do not log in to your online bank account from an insecure computer network.
- When accessing a bank's website, check that the URL is correct.
- Do not key in your account login details on a website which you are not sure about.
- When available, use alternative methods to enter your account login details, like using an on-screen keyboard.
- Scan your computer periodically to ensure that no spyware or key logger is installed and make sure that you have automatic updates turned on.
- Don't respond to e-mails asking you to enter your bank account details or any other personal information.

Chrome, have built-in anti-virus tools, so it's always better if you stick to them," says Ankit Fadia, one of the most famous ethical hackers. Banks and commercial enterprises operate with just a password, which seems to be the only hurdle for hackers. Fadia explains that with the rise of e-money having become popular in India only in the last couple of years, this "could be the peak time for phishing and identity theft". Identity theft comes in many guises. Recently, there have been incidents of freak e-mails sent

from people's personal IDs claiming that the particular person was stuck in a foreign country without money and passport and urging his or her friends to send money to a particular bank account. From a doctor in Kerala, to a professor in Pune, to a company executive in Kolkata, they not only faced embarrassing situations, with friends in their address books actually sending the money, but also frantic calls from well-wishers who then berated them. "I felt like a fool," says Samar Datta, one such victim. Fadia says these days there are

enough ways to send mails without even knowing the password of the user. Simply put, our money is just not safe anymore. Every time we open a bank website, it could be false. For example, icici.com could be icicic.com and we wouldn't even notice. To counter this, banks like Citibank or HSBC have now devised a small key-chain-like device which changes the customer's i-pin number every 30 seconds and above. That means, every time you log in, the current number in that device is your password which has definitely proven to be more effective than the standard i-pin.

But these matters are totally compounded by a very obsolete legal system. India's Information Technology (IT) Act, formulated in 2000, has not been updated since then and is ill-equipped to deal with the new forms of hacking and computer thefts that are emerging every day. "The IT Act has no provisions for data theft, so we have to look for other sections in the Indian Penal Code (IPC) to file such a case, like theft or under the corporate Act, or even copyright violation," says S.R. Raviprakash, an advocate with the Karnataka High Court and a sub-committee member of the Union IT Ministry. India's IT Act has three main offences listed—tampering source documents in computer hard disks, hacking, and publishing obscene information—all of which could earn imprisonment up to three years and/or a fine of up to Rs 2 lakh. "So, if one is phished, he/she has no legal rights, because the person gave up that information voluntarily," adds Raviprakash. He also says that it becomes even more difficult to nail these culprits as they cannot be booked under the IT Act but under other sections of the IPC, and therefore the case is taken away from the cyber crime cell which might have been able to crack it.

Raviprakash is hopeful that the revamped IT Act, on which the ministry is now working on, will take into account all the new forms of web offences. But right now, if you've been phished, hit the panic button. Get in touch with your bank if you wish, but believe that the money is lost forever. The only alternative is to be really, really careful when it comes to transacting on the Internet. ■